MANY STATES, ONE THEME

The BJP is framing illegal infiltration as the core issue in states with demographic anxiety

- **In Manipur, Modi warns** about demographic conspiracies in border areas, says a "demography mission" will free India of infiltrators
- **In Assam, he lauds CM Himanta Biswa Sarma**'s eviction drives as a model of reclaiming land from infiltrators, projecting them as acts of national defence
- **In W. Bengal, as CM Mamata Banerjee** protests pushbacks of Bangla-speaking Muslims, BJP hails the policy as proof of its tough stand on illegal immigration
- **Bihar's SIR is aimed** at weeding out illegal immigrants from voter lists and will now be rolled out across the country
- **The new Immigration and Foreigners Act** arms the Centre with powers of detection, detention and deportation of suspected infiltrators

women's collective Imagi Meira, dismisses the visit as superficial. "If Modi cares for Manipur, he should come with a proper plan instead of treating the visit as a stopover," she says. Arambam Noni, associate professor of political science at Dhanamanjuri University, is equally blunt. "Mega projects cannot substitute for trust-building, lasting peace and a serious reckoning with the state's deep-rooted divisions," she says. From the Kuki-Zo side, activist Hejang Misao read the separate stops in Imphal and Churachandpur as tacit acknowledgment of a divided polity, arguing that any real peace would require constitutional recognition of this divide. "We demand separate administration and Union Territory recognition—the only solution," says student leader Jacson Kuki.

BROADER ELECTORAL CANVAS

Speaking in Darrang district in Assam on September 14, Modi launched his most direct attack on illegal immigration and its alleged political patrons. Darrang had witnessed the most controversial eviction drives under CM Himanta Biswa Sarma's administration, with Bengali-speaking Muslims of immigrant origin removed from "encroached" land. Calling the Congress a "big protector of anti-nationals and infiltrators", Modi stated: "We will show the way we dedicate our lives to remove infiltrators." He thus cast the 2026 polls as a test of national allegiance. Modi's praise for the Sarma government's success in freeing "lakhs of bighas of land" from alleged encroachers explicitly linked evictions to national security imperatives. In his very first campaign speech in Assam in February 2014, Modi had vowed to oust illegal immigrants. That promise remains unfulfilled—the National Register of Citizens exercise, which excluded 1.9 million people, remains unimplemented. But the larger promise evidently remains useful.

West Bengal represents another battleground. After the Pahalgam terror attack, BJP-ruled states, including Haryana, Delhi and Maharashtra, had rounded up Bengali Muslims—mostly West Bengal natives—and "pushed them back" as "illegal Bangladeshis". West Bengal CM Mamata Banerjee has since accused the BJP of weaponising language and conflating Bengali identity with Bangladeshi nationality.

> **FORCIBLY PUSHING PEOPLE ACROSS THE BORDER IS A FAVOURED TOOL. NEARLY 3,000 ALLEGED BANGLADESHIS WERE PUSHED BACK IN 2025**

These 'pushbacks', or forcibly pushing people across the border without mutual verification, is a favoured tool. Nearly 3,000 alleged Bangladeshis were pushed back this year, compared to just 295 formal deportations in 2024. In Assam, Sarma revived the Immigrants (Expulsion from Assam) Act, 1950, empowering officials to expel anyone deemed harmful to public interest or to the scheduled tribes. Nearly 500 alleged Bangladeshis have been removed under the law in 2025.

Bihar, where Modi concluded his tour and inaugurated the Purnea airport in the Seemanchal region, presents yet another variation on the theme. The state is in the midst of a Special Intensive Revision (SIR) of electoral rolls, requiring voters added after 2003 to prove citizenship. Purnea offered a perfect setting for Modi as the BJP singles out the Seemanchal region, which borders Bengal and Nepal, as a symbol of demographic change driven by illegal immigration. In some districts here, Muslims make up over 60 per cent of the population. Modi's speech made the rhetoric official, declaring illegal infiltration as the source of a "demographic crisis" in Seemanchal. With the Election Commission of India confirming that SIR will be rolled out nationwide, including in election-bound West Bengal and Assam, "illegal infiltration" is set to gain a sharper edge.

The legislative architecture supporting this political offensive is also in place. The Immigration and Foreigners Act, 2025, enacted in April, grants sweeping powers to identify, detain and deport suspected illegal immigrants. The Centre's September directive, requiring states to establish detention centres, provides the administrative push.

Modi's eastern sojourn thus marks the launch of an electoral strategy that turns anxieties about demographic change into a binary political choice: those who support the BJP defend the nation, while those who oppose it protect infiltrators. ■